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Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Coverage Date: 1965-1971

Place Coverage: Zaka, Masvingo, Zimbabwe

Section Title(S)

a. The first signs of approaching maturity • b. The first monthly period

All this reveals the Karanga's natural enjoyment of sexual activities. The great stress laid on sexual differences leads to a refinement and intensification of the sexual life. One might call it a skilled elaboration of the sex-potential which, among other things, serves to maintain a happy relationship between the partners.

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At the beginning of puberty, the girls are separated from the boys, but despite this it is then that the first sexual "concessions" are made and the young girls learn more about their future sex-life. The growing Karanga girl is permitted to mix with her sisters' husbands, to eat and joke with them, the latter including the exchange of obscenities. This is what is called a joking relationship. Frequently, sisters-in-law become second or third wives, and the joking relationship is meant to smoothe the way for this eventuality.

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b. The first monthly period

Once she has begun to menstruate, a girl is called *mhandara*. The first menstruation is an event so important as to call for a new name for the girl (though not for the boy in a similar situation). *Mhanda* is the term for the branch of a tree, the implication being that the girl is now considered capable of bearing fruit. The time of the first menstruation is also called the "crossing

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of the river". By this term the Karanga refers to the flowing of the menstrual blood and the *bunha*'s moving towards a new part of her life; in a way, the girl herself has become a stream. When, after the dry season, the rains start to fill the rivers once more, Nature revives and bears fruit. So it is with the *mhandara*: she becomes fertile and hopes to bear a child in the amniotic fluid. The term "crossing the river" can, however, also occasionally be applied to the boy's first emission.

The Karanga has his own ideas as to what brings about a girl's first menstruation. He thinks the uterus is completely surrounded by a kind of membrane. When the *mafundo* (those round constructs in the "oviducts") come to life, this membrane gradually dissolves until, one day, the uterus opens and allows the blood to flow. As long as the uterus is enclosed by the membrane it is "blind"; the "eyes" of the uterus are opened by the first menstruation. From then on, it can really see – if only through the eyes of the woman. This ability to see is, as we shall see, of importance during pregnancy.

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